Sofia Pelica

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Education

PhD in Social Psychology: Human Behaviour and Infectious Diseases

Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam, the Netherlands. 2023 – Present
Supervisor: Professor J.M. Tybur. Co-Supervisor: Professor Catherine Molho.

MSc in Social and Organizational Psychology

Iscte – University Institute of Lisbon, Portugal. September 2020 – December 2022.

Grade: 19 out of 20. Highest-ranked student in this program's graduating class. Ranked first at the entrance of this program in 2020.

Research-based Thesis (graded 20 out of 20): *Adaptive Memory in Contamination Contexts: Emotionality as a Proximate Mechanism.* This research required electrocardiogram (ECG) and electrodermal activity (EDA) measures. The analysis was conducted using R and Python (see Appendices C and D for code).

BSc in Psychology

Iscte – University Institute of Lisbon, Portugal. September 2017 – June 2020.

Grade: 17 out of 20. Equivalent to First-Class Honours in the United Kingdom grading system.

Awards & Honors

Awarded Best Student by the Portuguese Government (DGES). Ranked in the top 0.01% of more than 14,000 students at Iscte for the 2021/2022 academic year (grade 19.7 out of 20).

Merit Scholarship: Top-Ranked BSc Psychology Student, Iscte, 2020. Awarded for achieving the highest grade among BSc Psychology students applying to the MSc program.

Publications & Preprints (* indicates cross-country project)

Communicable disease prevention and non-pharmaceutical interventions

1*. **Pelica, S.**, Molho, C., … & Tybur, J.M. (in preparation). Global variation in non-pharmaceutical interventions in 60 countries: The role of parasite stress and social norms.

2. **Pelica, S.**, Yifan, M., Molho, C., & Tybur, J.M. (in preparation). The shame of being unclean: Evaluative and emotional responses to pathogen-avoidance hygiene norm transgressions.

3*. Sun, H., Spadaro, G., **Pelica, S.**, … & Tybur, J.M. (2026). Interpersonal value regulates infection-risky social contact across 61 societies. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, *123*(42). https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2615739123

Population well-being

4*. Ruggeri, K., Valenzuela-Catarí, G., Polemiti, E., … Macchia, L., Ashcroft-Jones, S., & **Pelica, S.** (2026). Global mental wealth: A multidimensional analysis of social, financial, and emotional well-Being in 92 countries. *Social Indicators Research, 185*(11). https://doi.org/10.1007/s11205-026-03890-0 (see Quarto report).

5*. Ruggeri, K., Urday, R. O., **Pelica, S.**, & Ashcroft-Jones, S. (in preparation). New money, no money, and psychological inheritance in the elasticity of 21st century happiness.

Economic and financial health decision-making

6*. Ruggeri, K., Symone Tutuska, O., ..., **Pelica, S.**, ... & Ashcroft-Jones, S. (2023). The psychology and policy of overcoming economic inequality. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences, 46*, e174. https://doi.org/10.1017/ S0140525X23001103

7*. Ruggeri, K., Ashcroft-Jones, S., ..., **Pelica, S.**, ... & Stock, F. (2023). The persistence of cognitive biases in financial decisions across economic groups. *Scientific Reports, 13*(1), 10329. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-023-36339-2

8*. Priolo, G., Stablum, F., ..., **Pelica, S.,** ... & Rubaltelli, E. (2023). The robustness of mental accounting: a global perspective. (in-principle acceptance). *Journal of Consumer Research*. https://doi.org/10.31219/osf.io/apc26

9. **Pelica, S.** (in preparation). In which experts we trust? Comparing the influence of generative artificial intelligence and human expert advice on financial decisions.

Social Media Behavior

10*. Stock, F., **Pelica, S.**, Ashcroft-Jones, S., Stablum, F., ... Ruggeri, K., Hertwig, R., & Lorenz-Spreen, P. (2024). People in 26 countries prefer individual control to commercial or governmental control over online choice architectures. *OSF Preprint*. https://doi.org/10.31219/osf.io/haqu9

11*. Rathje, S., Asimovic, N., ..., **Pelica, S.,** ... & Van Bavel, J. (2025). Testing the causal impact of social media reduction around the globe. (Registered Report; in-principle acceptance). *Nature*.

Social perception, cultural influences and interpersonal processes

12. **Pelica, S.**, Aguiar, T., Frade, S., Guerra, R. & Prada, M. (2024). Are you what you emoji? How skin tone emojis and profile pictures shape attention and social inference processing. *Telematics and Informatics, 95*, 102207. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tele.2024.102207 (see Quarto report).

13*. Peters, K., Fagan, J., ..., **Pelica, S.,** ... & Inceoglu, I. (2026). Think political leader — think he or she? A multi-country test of a gender-fair language intervention to reduce gendered leadership stereotypes (2026). *The Leadership Quarterly*, *37*(6), 101991. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.leaqua.2026.101991

14*. Sirota, M., Srol, J., ..., **Pelica, S.,** ... & Schmidt, K. (2024). Mapping and increasing error correction behaviour in a culturally diverse sample (Preregistered report, submitted). *Nature Human Behaviour*.

15*. Grigoryan, L., Grigoryan, A., ..., **Pelica, S.,** ... & Pavlović, Z. (2024). (In)Alienable worth? Cultural logics of dignity, honor, and face and their links to prosociality across the world. *OSF Preprint*. https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/9hb8k_v1

Research Experience

Operations Manager

Junior Researcher Programme (JRP). October 2026 – Present, United Kingdom.

Member of the organising team

Junior Researcher Programme (JRP). December 2022 – October 2026, United Kingdom.

Visiting Researcher

Policy Research Group, University of Cambridge. August 2024, United Kingdom.
Project: People in 25 countries prefer to control their own online environments rather governments.

- Responsible for data preprocessing in R and codification in Qualtrics.
- Assisted with analysis and project administration.
- Recruited more than 500 volunteers from the Portuguese population.
- Oriented Bachelor's and Master's students in writing R code for analysis.

Junior Researcher, Project Manager

JRP. July 2021 – December 2022, United Kingdom.
Project: *Does Tax Choice Increase Tax Compliance? A Cross-Cultural Study.*

- Recruited more than 460 volunteers from the Portuguese population.
- Conducted data preprocessing with R.
- Contributed to the writing of the research paper.

Graduate Research Assistant

CIS – Center for Psychological Research and Social Intervention. May 2022 – October 2022, Portugal.

- Conducted more than 90 semi-structured interviews with children between 3 and 5 years old in an intervention project related to emotion regulation.

Project Collaborator, Team Manager

JDMLab – Judgement and Decision-Making Lab. April 2022 – September 2022, Italy.

- Elaborated JavaScript code for the survey on Qualtrics.
- Managed the team representing Portugal and recruited more than 250 volunteers.

Research Intern

JRP. July 2022 – August 2022, University of Cambridge, United Kingdom.
First Project: *The psychology and policy of overcoming economic inequality.*
Second Project: *Poor but not by choice(s): The persistence of cognitive biases across economic groups.*

- Recruited more than 350 volunteers from the Portuguese population.
- Conducted R analysis and preprocessing.
- Contributed to the writing of the research papers.

Curricular Research Intern

LAPSO – Laboratory of Social and Organizational Psychology. September 2021 – May 2022, Portugal.
Project: *Are you what you emoji? How skin tone emojis and profile pictures shape attention and social inference processing.*

- Worked on a research project as the first author.
- Collected and analysed data from ECG, EDA, and Eye tracking.

Graduate Research Assistant

CICANT – Center for Research in Applied Communication, Culture, and New Technologies.
September 2021 – September 2022, Portugal.
Project: *Love-Hate: interactions between social media users and influencers in hyperconnected times.*

- Conducted a literature review about cyberbullying.
- Analysed quantitative and qualitative data with SPSS and MAXQDA.

Undergraduate Research Assistant

CIS – Center for Psychological Research and Social Intervention. April 2019 – December 2019, Portugal.

- Collected data from ECG and EDA in the survival processing paradigm.
- Managed lab sessions and collected behavioural data through collaborative memory tasks.

Teaching Experience

Undergraduate Thesis Supervisor.

(January 2025 – Present). Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam.

Best Practices for Reproducible Data Processing and Analysis using R.

(2026). Workshop for BSc and MSc students at the Junior Researcher Programme.

Best Practices for Reproducible Data Processing and Analysis using R and Quarto.

(2025). Workshop with Sarah Ashcroft-Jones for PhD students at Kurt Lewin Instituut.

PsychoPy for Online Studies.

(2022). Workshop at LAPSO.

Presentations & Posters

Pelica, S., Molho, C., & Tybur, J. (September 18–19, 2025). *Global variation in non-pharmaceutical interventions: The role of parasite stress and social norms*.
Presentation: Conference of the Cognition & Behavior Evolution Network, Antwerp, Belgium.

Pelica, S., & Frade, S. (2023, March 31-1). *Once bitten, twice shy: The impact of predictive validity on anticipatory processing during sentence comprehension*.
Poster: Portuguese Association of Experimental Psychology, Lisbon, Portugal.

Pelica, S., Garrido, M., Saraiva, M., & Pandeirada, J. (March 9–11, 2023). *Adaptive memory in contamination context: Emotionality as a proximate mechanism*.
Poster: International Convention of Psychological Science, Brussels, Belgium.

Mariani*, S., Mitra*, M. L., **Pelica*, S**., Pyrkowski*, M., Toma*, S. & Silvia, F., (August 19–20, 2022). *Does tax choice increase tax compliance? A cross-cultural study*. * Shared position.
Presentation: JRP Conference, Cambridge, United Kingdom.

Pelica, S., Aguiar, T., Frade, S., Guerra, R., & Prada, M. (June 20–22, 2022). *The role of skin-tone emojis in impression formation*.
Presentation: XI National Symposium on Research in Psychology, UTAD – University of Trás-os-Montes and Alto Douro, Portugal.

Skills

Programming Languages: R, Python (attended Advanced Scientific Programming in Python, 2025), JavaScript.

Computational Tools & Software: Posit/RStudio, ShinyApp, Quarto, Docker, RMarkdown, Jupyter Lab, PsychoPy, Git, Qualtrics, Limesurvey, jsPsych, PsyToolkit, SPSS, JASP, Jamovi, NVivo, ATLAS, MAXQDA.

Media Processing: audio editing (Audacity), image manipulation (Adobe Photoshop, GIMP), video editing (DaVinci Resolve, Adobe Premiere Pro).

Web design: HTML, CSS.

Painting: 4 years of training in Fine Arts.

Film: 2 years of work experience as an assistant director.

Customer service: +1 year of work experience as a waitress.

Languages: Portuguese (native); English (C2).

Community Engagement & Leadership

Creator of Computational Reproducibility Lesson Plans and Pedagogical Slides for the Framework for Open and Reproducible Research Training (2025).

Member of the Open Science Community Amsterdam (2024 – Present).

Volunteer at the International Convention of Psychological Science (2023). Association for Psychological Science.

Volunteer at the XVII Ph.D. Meeting in Psychology (2022). Iscte – University Institute of Lisbon.

Member of the Pedagogical Commission (2017 – 2020). Iscte – University Institute of Lisbon.

Class Representative (2017 – 2019). Iscte – University Institute of Lisbon.

Reference contacts:

Professor J.M. Tybur, j.m.tybur@vu.nl

Professor Kai Ruggeri, kai.ruggeri@columbia.edu

Dr. Sarah Ashcroft-Jones, sa4422@cumc.columbia.edu